

Unschooling Education Without a Map

A field guide for families who want to switch to a different path.

by Giulia Pacciotti / Wild Hearts Rising

This guide grew out of several years of slow travel across Europe with my son, living without a fixed address, without a curriculum, and without a backup plan. It is not a how-to manual. It is more like notes passed under the table from someone still mid-journey to someone who just started wondering if the table is even the right place to be.

Free to share. Free to print. Not a substitute for trusting yourself.

1. What Unschooling Actually Is

Unschooling is not homeschooling with the worksheets removed. It is not unparenting or leave kids figuring it out themselves. It is not waiting for your child to spontaneously become a mathematician. It is the radical (and completely reasonable, once you sit with it) idea that human beings learn constantly, naturally, and best when the learning comes from genuine curiosity rather than compliance.

John Holt, who first articulated much of this in the 1960s and 70s, noticed that children who were allowed to follow their own interests did not become passive or ignorant. They became deeply competent in the things that mattered to them, and surprisingly capable of picking up everything else when they needed it.

What it looks like in practice varies wildly. For us it has looked like: learning maths through cooking and money management across real budgets; learning history by standing inside it (you pick things up differently when you are physically in a medieval village than when you are reading about one); learning to read and write on a timeline that had nothing to do with any school's schedule.

What it is not:

- Doing nothing and hoping for the best.
- A rejection of knowledge or discipline.
- Only for children who would have "thrived anyway."
- A permanent state of chaos and ferality (though some days it is).
- Something that requires a large house, a garden, and a trust fund.

"The thing is, once you stop asking whether your child is keeping up with their class, you start seeing what they are actually doing. It is a lot."

2. The Fear Inventory

Every unschooling parent I have ever talked to has the same fear underneath the specific fears. The specific fears sound like: what if they never learn to read, what if they can not get a job, what if people judge me. The fear underneath all of them is: what if I have broken something that can not be fixed.

I want to offer you the fear inventory. Not to dismiss the fears (some of them are worth taking seriously) but to separate the ones that are based on evidence from the ones that are based on a culture that has decided there is only one shape a childhood can take.

The Fear	What the Evidence Actually Says
They will not learn to read.	Late readers catch up. Literacy tied to coercion often creates lifelong aversion. Unschooled kids read when reading becomes useful or interesting to them.
They will be socially awkward.	School socialisation is one of the strangest social environments humans have invented: thirty same-age strangers, sitting in rows, not allowed to talk. Real socialisation looks different.
They will not be able to go to university.	Plenty of unschooled young people enter higher education. The route is different, not closed.
I am not qualified to do this.	You do not need to be the expert. You need to be the person who helps them find the experts, the resources, the experiences. That is a different job.
People will think I am irresponsible.	Yes. Some will. That particular fear does not get smaller by abandoning the thing you believe in.

A personal note on the first one: my son started reading at 8. At 12 he has worked through most of the classics, mythology, and fantasy available to him in three languages. As a natural consequence, he started writing. Plots and poems. Nobody intervened unless asked for some guidance.

3. Learning While Travelling

Travel is not a supplement to education. For us it has been the education, with everything else built around it. This is not a romantic statement. Some weeks it is exhausting and logistically brutal and nothing goes right.

But the learning that happens when you move through the world is qualitatively different from the learning that happens inside a room designed for the purpose. It sticks differently. It connects to the body, to memory, to actual consequence.

What travel teaches that curricula struggle to:

- Adaptability as a default setting, not a skill you have to teach.
- That there is more than one way to organise a society, a meal, a school day, a life.
- Languages absorb more quickly when you need them to buy bread or play with kids in a foreign park.
- History as something that happened to real people in real places, not something in a chapter.
- How to manage uncertainty, navigate the unfamiliar, and ask for help across a language barrier.
- That boredom in an interesting place is actually quite productive.

A note on screens and devices: we use them. Extensively. Maps, translation, documentation, podcasts, YouTube rabbit holes about Byzantine history. The device is not the enemy of learning. The absence of curiosity is. And curiosity, in my experience, does not disappear when you stop forcing the curriculum.

4. The Practical Architecture

People often ask what a typical day looks like. The honest answer is: it depends on the week, the country, the mood, the season. But there are some things that have stayed consistent.

Things we do consistently:

Morning movement: Daily, non-negotiable. What counts as movement has ranged from organised sport and coastline trekkings to wandering around a new city for six hours.

Real-world maths: Budgeting for the week, comparing prices, investing, calculating distances and travel times.

Project-led deep dives: When something catches his interest, we follow it properly. This has included: volcanoes, fishing, Medieval siege warfare, the history of cheese, coding, wild foraging and several months of mythology triggered by a single ruined wall in France.

Reading: Whatever we are each reading. No assigned texts. This has been going on for years and has produced a reader who will not stop.

Conversation: About everything. This is probably the thing I would miss most if we had sent him to school.

Things we do not do:

- Replicate school at home.
- Panic when a week passes without anything that looks like "learning."
- Pretend this is easy all the time.

We basically do not distinguish playing from learning, life from holiday. And this, I think, is the whole point.

5. The Part Nobody Talks About

The hardest part of unschooling is not the logistics or the curriculum gaps or the social questions. It is the sustained requirement to trust yourself in a culture that is specifically designed to make you doubt yourself on this topic.

The doubt does not come just from strangers. It comes from family members who love you. It comes from your own 3am spirals when you wonder if you have made a catastrophic mistake. It comes from the moments when your child is not interested in anything that looks educational for what feels like a dangerously long time.

I have been there for years. Pretty much 8 to 9 years of it.

What I have found useful, for what it is worth:

1. Keep notes on what they are actually doing, not just what looks like learning. You will be surprised.
2. Find one other person who is doing this. Just one. The isolation is the hardest part and it is not necessary.
3. Separate "I am worried right now" from "this is genuinely not working." They feel the same but they are not.
4. Remember that most adults learn most of what they actually use for their lives after they leave formal education. The system was never as essential as it insisted it was.
5. Let yourself be wrong sometimes. This is not a perfect system either. It is just a different set of tradeoffs.

"The confidence to do this without a safety net does not come before you jump. It comes from having jumped and not died."

6. Resources Worth Having

I am not going to give you a comprehensive reading list because comprehensive reading lists are where motivation goes to die. Here are the things that have actually been useful.

Books:

How Children Learn / How Children Fail John Holt. The original. Still the clearest articulation of what goes wrong in conventional schooling and why.

Free to Learn Peter Gray. The evolutionary case for unschooling. Useful when you need the research to back up the instinct.

The Teenage Liberation Handbook Grace Llewellyn. Written for teenagers, genuinely useful for parents too. The energy is right.

Dumbing Us Down John Taylor Gatto. A former teacher's account of what school actually does. Not comforting, but clarifying.

Children of Summerhill A.S. Neill. Told through the children's own words and stories. Worth it for the children themselves, who are more articulate about freedom and self-direction than most adults.

Online:

- Peter Gray's Psychology Today blog (search "Freedom to Learn") for ongoing research.
- Sandra Dodd's website (sandraddodd.com) for the most thorough thinking on radical unschooling.
- The Alliance for Self-Directed Education (ASDE) for community and research.
- Any Facebook group with "unschooling" and your country in the title. The local legal information is invaluable.

On the legal side:

Laws vary enormously by country and even by region within countries. France, where I have spent considerable time, has specific notification requirements. Unschooling is basically declared illegal while in substance it is just smoke and mirrors to discourage people from being free. Nobody can force you to send your kids to school. You can legally refuse. As you can legally refuse vaccinations.

Be careful not to sign any document or schedule, as that basically says you accept to comply with unreasonable rules and you can be investigated.

I still have residency in Italy, where I simply refused to send my son to school at age 6. No explanation needed.

Find your local home education association first. They will know the current law better than anyone. And then connect with others who are doing it through social media. We are growing exponentially, even after all governments trying to shut us down.

A Last Thing

I am not holding this up as the right choice for every family. I am holding it up as a real choice, one that works, one that does not require you to be a particular type of person or have a particular type of income or live in a particular type of place.

We have done it without a safety net, across multiple countries, on a budget that required real creativity. The thing I would tell the version of myself standing at the beginning of this, stomach in knots, wondering if I was ruining everything:

"You are paying more attention to your child than the system ever would. That is most of what this requires."

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If this little guide found you at the right moment, pass it on. No permission needed.